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■ **By Raj Chengappa and
Hasan Zaidi in Pakistan**

If Asif Ali Zardari took over as the next prime minister of Pakistan he would probably be the country's best dressed premier in recent times. Wearing a dark blue suit, hair brushed fashionably back, he is a picture of sartorial elegance in his Islamabad house as he greets the throngs of visitors who have come to congratulate him on the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) emerging as the single largest party in the general elections.

Till about two months ago, Zardari was better known as Benazir Bhutto's worse half, a political liability. After her horrific assassination on December 27, 2007, he took centre stage, becoming co-chairman of the party and anointing his young son Bilawal as the heir apparent. Those who observed him during the 40-day mourning period, in which he remained mostly confined to her ancestral house in Larkana, saw him acquire a steely determination to continue her unfulfilled agenda. He seemed to grow into the mantle that had been thrust on him. Now after the election results he can choose to be the king or the kingmaker. Whichever role he selects, it is clear that he is the new boss in town.

That is primarily because the results of the 2008 general elections have not followed the script that the skeptics had prepared. All the opposition parties, including PPP, had charged President Pervez Musharraf with rigging the polls. A widespread belief was that he would engineer a majority for the so-called King's party, the Pakistan Muslim League (Quaid-e-Azam), PML(Q), and consolidate his position. But the people of Pakistan decided to come out in large numbers to write a script of their own. The King's party has been routed, PPP has emerged as the single largest party and the biggest surprise has come from the strong show by former prime minister Nawaz Sharif, whose party, the Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz), PML(N), has come a handsome second.

In doing so, Sharif and Zardari have emerged as Pakistan's new power duo—spearheading the tectonic shift that has already shaken and could possibly even topple Musharraf's dictatorial regime. There are larger responsibilities that the electorate has entrusted the two leaders with. Nine years of Musharraf's rule had begun taking its toll and in the past one year every major democratic institution, especially the judiciary, had been trampled upon to allow the former general to hang on to power. Cricketer-turned politician Imran Khan, who stayed out of the election